

Putnam 1993 Claude Guide

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1 Central Claims

- The performance of democratic institutions varies dramatically and systematically across regions, and this variation is explained not primarily by wealth, formal institutional design, or contemporary political choices, but by the depth and density of **civic community**—the accumulated stock of norms, networks, and trust that characterize a region’s social life.
- **Social capital**—defined as the features of social organization (networks of civic engagement, norms of reciprocity, and social trust) that facilitate coordination and cooperation for mutual benefit—is the central explanatory variable. Regions with high social capital have better-performing governments; regions with low social capital have worse-performing governments.
- Social capital is **self-reinforcing**: communities with dense civic networks and high interpersonal trust find it easier to cooperate, which produces better collective outcomes, which in turn reinforce trust and civic engagement—a virtuous cycle. The inverse—low trust, weak networks, poor institutions, defection—constitutes a vicious cycle equally difficult to escape.
- **History is decisive**: the differences in civic traditions between northern and southern Italy trace back nearly a thousand years, to the communal republics of medieval northern Italy versus the Norman autocracy of the south. Contemporary institutional performance is deeply path-dependent on these historical legacies.
- The **creation of regional governments** in Italy in 1970—a natural quasi-experiment—provides the empirical basis for the study. Because all regions received identical formal institutions simultaneously, variation in subsequent institutional performance can be attributed to pre-existing social and civic conditions rather than institutional design.
- **Economic development does not cause civic community**: while civic regions tend to be wealthier, this is because civic community enables economic development, not the reverse. The historical and cross-sectional evidence supports civic culture as causally prior to economic prosperity.
- The book’s findings challenge both **institutional design optimism** (the view that the right formal rules can produce good governance regardless of social context) and **modernization theory** (the view that economic development automatically produces democratic capacity). Social capital must be accumulated over long periods; it cannot be engineered quickly.

2 Core Case Studies and Empirical Strategy

- **The Italian regional reform of 1970**: Italy created fifteen ordinary regional governments (later twenty) with identical constitutional structures and powers. This allows

Putnam to treat regions as comparable units receiving the same “treatment” (new institutions) and to observe divergence in performance as a function of pre-existing conditions—a natural experiment design.

- **Northern Italy (Emilia-Romagna, Lombardy, etc.):** The paradigmatic high-civic-community cases. Dense networks of voluntary associations, cooperative economies, high interpersonal trust, active political participation, and strong regional government performance. Traced to the medieval communes.
- **Southern Italy (Calabria, Sicily, Campania, etc.):** The paradigmatic low-civic-community cases. Vertical patron-client relations, low interpersonal trust, weak voluntary associations, political clientelism, and poor regional government performance. Traced to the Norman and Bourbon autocracies.
- **The Mezzogiorno problem:** Southern Italian underdevelopment and institutional dysfunction are treated not as a failure of policy but as the product of a centuries-long civic deficit reinforced by path dependence. Putnam is skeptical that standard development interventions can overcome this legacy quickly.
- **The Institutional Performance Index:** Putnam and colleagues construct a composite index of regional government performance across twelve indicators (cabinet stability, budget promptness, statistical and information services, reform legislation, legislative innovation, daycare centers, family clinics, industrial policy instruments, agricultural spending capacity, local health unit expenditures, housing and urban development, bureaucratic responsiveness). This operationalization is central to the book’s empirical claims.
- **The Civic Community Index:** Measured via four indicators: (1) preference voting in elections (lower = more civic, since preference voting reflects clientelism); (2) referendum turnout; (3) newspaper readership; (4) density of sports and cultural associations. These are combined into a single index that strongly predicts institutional performance.
- **Longitudinal evidence:** Putnam traces civic traditions back through the medieval period using archival data on the presence of communal self-governance, guild networks, and mutual aid societies—establishing that the civic/uncivic divide predates any modern economic or institutional differences.

3 Core Works Cited

- **Alexis de Tocqueville**, *Democracy in America* (1835/1840)—the foundational source for the idea that voluntary associations and civic participation are both products of and contributors to democratic self-governance; Putnam’s social capital concept is deeply Tocquevillian.
- **James Coleman**, “Social Capital in the Creation of Human Capital” (1988, *American Journal of Sociology*)—the most important proximate source for Putnam’s social capi-

tal concept; Coleman defines social capital as aspects of social structure that facilitate individual action.

- **Mancur Olson**, *The Logic of Collective Action* (1965)—the baseline problem that social capital solves: why rational individuals fail to cooperate even when cooperation would benefit everyone. Social capital reduces the costs of collective action and mitigates free-riding.
- **Robert Axelrod**, *The Evolution of Cooperation* (1984)—the game-theoretic foundation for Putnam’s claim that repeated interaction, trust, and norms of reciprocity can sustain cooperation without centralized enforcement.
- **Glenn Loury**, “A Dynamic Theory of Racial Income Differences” (1977)—an early use of “social capital” to describe resources embedded in social networks; acknowledged by Putnam as a precursor.
- **Edward Banfield**, *The Moral Basis of a Backward Society* (1958)—the study of “amoral familism” in a southern Italian village (Montegrano) that most directly prefigures Putnam’s argument about civic deficits; Putnam engages and extends Banfield’s account.
- **Sidney Tarrow**, *Peasant Communism in Southern Italy* (1967) and related work—comparative Italian regional politics; provides historical and empirical context for the north-south civic divide.
- **Gabriel Almond and Sidney Verba**, *The Civic Culture* (1963)—the foundational work on political culture and its relationship to democratic performance; Putnam’s civic community concept is related but more structural and less attitudinal.
- **David Landes**, *The Unbound Prometheus* (1969) and related work on economic history—background on the economic development of northern Italy and the role of social organization in industrial growth.
- **Douglass North**, *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance* (1990)—on path dependence and the lock-in of institutional arrangements; Putnam uses North’s framework to explain why civic deficits persist.
- **Albert Hirschman**, *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) and work on civic engagement in Latin America—on the conditions under which citizens engage versus exit from collective institutions; relevant to the dynamics of civic community.
- **Peter Evans, Dietrich Rueschemeyer, and Theda Skocpol** (eds.), *Bringing the State Back In* (1985)—the statist tradition that Putnam partially challenges by arguing that social conditions, not state capacity per se, drive institutional performance.

4 Chapter 1: Introduction — Studying Institutional Performance

- **The puzzle:** Why do some democratic institutions work and others fail? Putnam frames this as the central question of democratic theory that existing accounts—focused on formal rules, economic conditions, or political leadership—have inadequately answered.
- **The research design:** The 1970 Italian regional reform creates a unique natural experiment. Twenty regions receive identical institutions; they diverge dramatically in performance. This divergence demands explanation from pre-existing conditions, not institutional design.
- **The study’s scope:** Putnam and his colleagues (Robert Leonardi and Raffaella Nanetti) followed the Italian regions from 1970 to 1989—nearly two decades—allowing observation of institutional development and performance over time rather than at a single point.
- **Questions driving the inquiry:** What makes institutions succeed? What conditions are required for democratic governance to produce public goods effectively? How do historical legacies shape contemporary political capacity?
- **Preview of the argument:** Social and civic context—not formal rules, economic resources, or political will alone—is the primary determinant of institutional performance. The “social capital” of a community shapes whether formal institutions can function effectively.

5 Chapter 2: Changing the Rules — Two Decades of Institutional Development

- **The 1970 reform:** Italy’s constitutional reform established regional governments with substantial legislative, administrative, and fiscal competencies—replacing centralized administration with regional self-governance. All regions started with the same powers, budgets (on a per capita basis), and formal structures.
- **Divergence over time:** Within a decade, regional governments diverged sharply in their administrative capacity, legislative output, and policy innovation. Some regions became effective and innovative policymakers; others remained clientelistic, slow, and unresponsive.
- **Institutional isomorphism at the start:** The formal similarity of the new regional institutions at founding is critical to the research design—it rules out institutional differences as an explanation for divergence and focuses attention on pre-existing social conditions.
- **Patterns of political change:** In the early years, regional politics was dominated by national party organizations; over time, regions developed distinct political cultures and

styles of governance. Northern regions moved toward programmatic, effective policy delivery; southern regions remained trapped in clientelistic networks.

- **The “virtuous” and “vicious” circles emerge:** Already by the late 1970s, Putnam and colleagues observed the emergence of divergent equilibria—high-performance regions improving further while low-performance regions stagnated or regressed.

6 Chapter 3: Measuring Institutional Performance

- **The Institutional Performance Index (IPI):** Putnam constructs a composite measure of regional government performance using twelve indicators across three domains: policy processes (stability, promptness, statistical capacity), policy pronouncements (legislative output and innovation), and policy implementation (actual service delivery and spending capacity).
- **The twelve indicators:** Cabinet stability; budget promptness; statistical and information services; reform legislation; legislative innovation; daycare centers; family clinics; industrial policy instruments; agricultural spending capacity; local health unit expenditures; housing and urban development; bureaucratic responsiveness (measured via a simulated “client” procedure). These are combined into a single additive index.
- **Consistency of the measure:** The IPI is highly internally consistent (indicators correlate strongly) and stable over time, suggesting it captures a real underlying dimension of institutional performance rather than noise.
- **The north-south gradient:** The IPI reveals a stark and consistent north-south gradient in Italian regional government performance—northern and central regions cluster at the high end, southern regions at the low end, with very few exceptions.
- **Citizen satisfaction:** Citizen surveys about satisfaction with regional government closely track the IPI, validating the index against subjective assessments. Citizens in high-IPI regions report greater satisfaction and trust in regional government.
- **Methodological contribution:** The IPI represents an early effort to rigorously operationalize “good governance” in comparative politics—anticipating subsequent work on governance measurement (World Bank governance indicators, V-Dem, etc.).

7 Chapter 4: Explaining Institutional Performance — Socioeconomic Modernity or Civic Community?

- **The rival hypothesis:** The most obvious alternative explanation for divergent institutional performance is economic development. Wealthier, more modernized regions may simply have more resources and human capital to support effective governance.

- **Civic community as the alternative:** Putnam develops the concept of **civic community**—characterized by active citizen participation in public affairs, civic equality (horizontal rather than vertical relations), solidarity and trust, and dense associational life—as the true explanatory variable.
- **Measuring civic community:** The Civic Community Index combines: (1) low preference voting (a proxy for non-clientelism), (2) high referendum turnout, (3) high newspaper readership, (4) high density of sports and cultural associations. These four indicators load on a single factor in factor analysis.
- **Civic community vs. economic development:** Both correlate with institutional performance, but when civic community and economic development are entered together in regression analysis, civic community retains a strong independent effect while economic development's effect diminishes substantially. Civic community is the more powerful predictor.
- **Causal priority of civic community:** Using data going back to the early twentieth century, Putnam shows that civic community in 1900–1920 predicts economic development in later decades—suggesting civic community is causally prior to economic modernization, not the reverse.
- **The social capital mechanism:** Civic community works through **social capital**: networks of civic engagement generate norms of generalized reciprocity, which enable individuals to cooperate and trust one another beyond immediate kin or patron-client relationships, which in turn enables collective action and effective governance.
- **The prisoner's dilemma resolution:** Social capital solves the collective action problem at the heart of governance: in high-social-capital communities, individuals cooperate because they expect others to cooperate (generalized trust), because networks monitor and sanction defection, and because repeated interaction makes defection costly.

8 Chapter 5: Tracing the Roots of the Civic Community

- **The historical question:** Why do some Italian regions have high civic community and others do not? Putnam traces the answer back nearly a millennium, to the emergence of self-governing communes in northern and central Italy in the eleventh and twelfth centuries.
- **The communal republics of northern Italy:** Between roughly 1100 and 1300, northern Italian city-states (Florence, Venice, Bologna, etc.) developed sophisticated forms of self-governance—guilds, mutual aid societies, neighborhood associations, and representative councils. These institutions cultivated habits of civic participation, horizontal trust, and collective self-regulation.

- **The Norman kingdom of southern Italy:** In the same period, southern Italy was governed by the Norman monarchy and later the Hohenstaufen and Angevin dynasties—highly centralized, autocratic regimes that suppressed horizontal civic organization and organized society through vertical patron-client networks. Citizens related to power vertically (through patrons) rather than horizontally (through civic peers).
- **Path dependence:** These divergent social equilibria proved remarkably stable. Each generation inherited the norms, networks, and expectations of the previous one; civic regions reproduced civic culture across centuries; uncivic regions reproduced vertical dependency. The civic map of contemporary Italy closely mirrors the political geography of medieval Italy.
- **The statistical evidence:** Putnam presents data showing that indicators of medieval communal development (presence of independent city-states, guild activity, etc.) in the twelfth through fourteenth centuries predict civic community indicators in the twentieth century—a thousand-year correlation that is striking in its stability.
- **The “equilibrium trap” of southern Italy:** Southern regions are caught in a self-reinforcing equilibrium: low trust makes civic engagement risky, which prevents the development of civic networks, which perpetuates low trust. No single actor can exit this trap unilaterally, because cooperation requires mutual expectations that can only be built collectively over time.
- **The implications for institutional reform:** If civic community traces to medieval history, then contemporary institutional reform cannot easily or quickly build civic capacity. The implication is deeply pessimistic about rapid democratic development in low-social-capital contexts.

9 Chapter 6: Social Capital and Institutional Success

- **Social capital defined:** Putnam defines social capital as “features of social organization, such as trust, norms, and networks, that can improve the efficiency of society by facilitating coordinated actions.” It is a property of communities, not individuals, and is accumulated collectively over time.
- **Three components:**
 - **Norms of generalized reciprocity:** the expectation that a favor rendered now will be returned by someone (not necessarily the same person) in the future. This differs from specific reciprocity (“I’ll do this if you do that”) and enables large-scale cooperation among strangers.
 - **Networks of civic engagement:** voluntary associations, clubs, cooperatives, and other horizontal organizations that bring citizens into regular contact, build trust through repeated interaction, and create channels for collective action.

- **Social trust:** the generalized belief that other members of the community are trustworthy, enabling cooperative behavior in low-information environments where individual reputation cannot be directly assessed.
- **The virtuous circle:** High social capital enables cooperation → cooperation produces collective goods → collective goods reinforce trust and civic engagement → higher social capital. This self-reinforcing dynamic explains both stability and path dependence.
- **Social capital and formal institutions:** Formal institutions work better where social capital is high because: citizens monitor and sanction officials more effectively; officials internalize civic norms; coordination among government agencies is easier when trust is high; and citizens comply with rules they believe others will also follow.
- **Horizontal vs. vertical social capital:** Not all social organization creates the same capital. **Horizontal** networks (among equals) build generalized trust and civic capacity. **Vertical** networks (patron-client hierarchies) may solve local coordination problems but do not generate generalized trust and can actively undermine civic community by making individuals dependent on patrons rather than civic peers.
- **Social capital as a public good:** Because social capital benefits everyone in the community (not just those who generate it), it is underprovided by private action—another reason why its accumulation requires sustained collective effort and historical time.
- **The Mezzogiorno revisited:** Southern Italian dysfunction is not caused by individual irrationality or cultural pathology but by a rational response to a low-social-capital equilibrium. Defection, clientelism, and distrust are individually rational when no one else can be trusted to cooperate—the tragedy is structural, not moral.

10 Methodological Contributions and Limitations

- **The natural experiment:** The simultaneous creation of formally identical regional governments across Italy is one of the cleanest natural experiments in comparative politics at the time of writing—allowing cross-regional comparison while holding institutional design constant.
- **Mixed methods integration:** The book combines quantitative cross-regional analysis (regression, factor analysis, index construction), historical archival research (medieval communal records), and qualitative case studies of specific regional governments. This integration is methodologically exemplary for the era.
- **The endogeneity problem:** The most significant methodological challenge is that civic community and institutional performance may be mutually reinforcing (the virtuous circle), making it difficult to establish causal direction. Putnam’s response—showing that historical civic indicators (from the medieval period and early twentieth century) predict contemporary performance—is the strongest available evidence for causal priority of civic

community.

- **Measurement of social capital:** The Civic Community Index relies on behavioral indicators (association density, newspaper readership, turnout) rather than attitudinal measures (survey-based trust questions). This is methodologically advantageous (behaviors are less subject to social desirability bias) but limits comparability with survey-based social capital research.
- **Generalizability:** The findings are based on a single country—Italy—over a specific historical period. Whether social capital operates similarly in non-Western contexts, newer democracies, or federal systems outside Europe is a question the book cannot fully answer.
- **The “dark side” of social capital:** Putnam largely focuses on civic associations with broadly public-regarding effects. Critics have noted that tightly-knit groups can generate social capital internally while producing negative externalities for outsiders (mafia networks, ethnic gangs, exclusive clubs)—a tension between **bonding** and **bridging** social capital that Putnam addresses more fully in later work (*Bowling Alone*, 2000).
- **Agency and structure:** The historical path-dependence argument risks determinism—if civic community traces to medieval history and is self-reinforcing, it is unclear how any community escapes a low-social-capital trap. Putnam offers no clear mechanism for escaping vicious circles, which has attracted substantial criticism.

11 Connections to the Broader Literature

- **Tocqueville:** The book is self-consciously Tocquevillian—voluntary associations are the school of democracy, civic engagement produces the habits of mind that make self-governance possible. Putnam operationalizes and tests empirically what Tocqueville argued normatively and descriptively.
- **Huntington 1968:** Huntington argues that political development requires institutionalization to manage participation; Putnam implicitly agrees that institutions require a social foundation, but locates that foundation in civic community rather than in formal organizational capacity. The two accounts are compatible but differently weighted: Huntington emphasizes institutional design, Putnam emphasizes social preconditions.
- **Dahl 1972:** Dahl’s polyarchy requires organizational pluralism and activist beliefs—both of which are proxies for what Putnam would call social capital. Putnam provides a more developed account of the social mechanisms underlying Dahl’s conditions and a more explicit causal story about where those conditions come from historically.
- **Olson 1965:** Putnam is in direct conversation with Olson’s collective action problem. Where Olson is pessimistic about voluntary cooperation, Putnam argues that social capital—accumulated historically—can solve the prisoner’s dilemma without selective incentives or coercion.

- **Modernization theory (Lipset, Dahl Chapter 6):** Putnam challenges the direction of causality in the development-democracy relationship. Socioeconomic modernization does not automatically produce civic community; rather, civic community produces both economic development and effective governance. This is a direct reversal of the standard modernization account.
- **Path dependence (North 1990):** Putnam's historical argument is one of the most dramatic applications of path dependence in political science—a thousand-year lock-in of social equilibria. This connects to the broader institutionalist literature on increasing returns and historical contingency.
- **Subsequent social capital research:** The book launched an enormous research program. Putnam extended the argument to the United States in *Bowling Alone* (2000), documenting a secular decline in American social capital since the 1960s. Critics (Portes, Foley, Edwards) have challenged the concept's theoretical coherence, measurement, and applicability across contexts.